Fusion of functions revisited: Independent determinatives in English

Brett Reynolds *
Humber Polytechnic & University of Toronto

18th October 2026

Abstract

When does one constituent have two functions at once? *The Cambridge Grammar of the English Language* treats *some* in *take some* as both determiner and head of its noun phrase, and *few* in *the lucky few* as both modifier and head. Payne et al. (2007) make this fusion of functions explicit and build their case on *once*, *twice*, and *thrice*. The alternative treats the word as a head and nothing more. To choose, this paper proposes a test: a property of form counts as evidence for a second function if it varies with that function rather than with the word. Using the grammar's own diagnostics and corpus data, I find none for the modifier function, nothing further in Payne et al.'s constructions, and one for the determiner function: the absence of an adjective before a bare determinative (**Lucky few escaped*). That fact favours fusion, but not enough to outweigh the generality of treating the word as a head and the cost of a constituent with two parents. Fused relatives differ. Subject relativization and the ban on infinitival forms reflect the relative word's function inside its clause, and in usage the case of *whoever* answers to that function and to the function of the whole phrase. Fusion is favoured there, though not forced.

Keywords: determinatives; fused heads; headedness; noun phrase; quantifiers; English grammar

AI use. The large language models GPT-6 (Astra), Claude Fable 5.1, Claude Opus 5 and 5.5, Claude Haiku 4.5, GLM-5.3-Flash, Muse Wonder 1.0, and GPT-5.6 (Sol) served as drafting and editing aids throughout the preparation of this paper. I am responsible for all theoretical claims, arguments, errors, and interpretive choices.

1 Introduction

When one expression seems to have two functions at once, what should persuade us that it does? In *some apples*, *some* determines the noun phrase, and the noun *apples* is its head. In *I'll take* [*some*], *some* is the whole noun phrase, and there's no noun to be its head. One influential analysis gives *some* both functions there: it's the determiner of its noun phrase and the phrase's head at once. This paper asks what evidence could justify that doubling.

*Contact: brett.reynolds@humber.ca

The doubling is called FUSION OF FUNCTIONS. Its most explicit statements are in *The Cambridge Grammar of the English Language* (*CGEL*; Huddleston and Pullum, 2002) and in Payne et al. (2007). In *take some*, *CGEL*'s *some* is a fused determiner-head. In *the lucky few* and *the rich*, *few* and *rich* are fused modifier-heads, at once modifier and head (pp. 410–421). Payne et al. make the device explicit, extend it to *once*, *twice*, and *thrice*, and say what it costs.

It departs from canonical structure twice. A constituent with two functions "will in effect have two mothers", which they call "the major departure from canonical principles of structure" (p. 570). And the head of a noun phrase can turn out to be a determinative or an adjective, not a noun, "the second departure" (p. 571). The question is when a grammar should accept the first.

Many syntacticians would sidestep it. The determinative could head the whole noun phrase, as on the DP hypothesis (see Miller & Pullum, 2022; Salzmann, 2020), or a silent noun could follow *some* (Kester, 1996; Lobeck, 1995). Each route gives up one of three commitments *CGEL* argues for (Section 2): where a noun phrase has a noun, the noun is its head and the determinative a dependent; *some* keeps its category when it stands alone; and there's no silent head noun. This paper keeps all three, since they're the premises that led to fusion, and asks whether fusion follows from them. It doesn't. The result is conditional on those commitments, but the criterion behind it applies to a second function in any analysis.

The alternative I call ORDINARY HEAD. The phrase that *CGEL* fuses has one function, head of the NOMINAL, as a common noun does in *take* [*apples*]. The nominal is the unit between noun and noun phrase, such as *old man* in *the old man*. Since the two analyses describe the same strings, choosing between them takes a criterion, and I put the burden on the second function. A property of form counts as evidence for it if it varies with that function and not with the word alone, and the evidence is weighed against the extra structure (Section 2).

The test finds no such property where a word that's elsewhere a modifier heads a nominal, as in *the lucky few*, *the rich*, and *nylon* in *I prefer cotton shirts to* [*nylon*] (Section 4). Where a determinative stands alone, as in *take some*, it finds one, taken up below (Section 3); the genitive, which *CGEL* ties to fusion (p. 420), divides these words one by one, not by function. *Once*, *twice*, and *thrice* add nothing, and their term-of-office uses (*the once mayor*) come out as ordinary modifiers (Section 5).

The one property the test finds is the absence of an adjective before a bare determinative (**Lucky few escaped*).[1] Fusion derives it, where ordinary Head has to state it as a condition, one of a kind *CGEL* already states for pronouns, so it counts as evidence for the determiner function. Section 6 weighs that advantage against the generality ordinary Head gains and the constituents with two parents it avoids. On balance I take the phrase *CGEL* fuses to be an ordinary head, more clearly for the modifier function than for the determiner function, though the evidence doesn't force that conclusion.

Fused relatives are another matter (Section 7). In [*Whoever told you that*] *can't have read the report carefully*, *whoever* is head of the subject noun phrase and also the subject of *told you that* (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 1076). On the alternative, the relative word simply heads the noun phrase and the clause modifies it (Bresnan & Grimshaw, 1978). But the second function shows in form, twice categorically and once as a preference. Fused relatives relativize their subject, which bare relatives in standard English can't do. They're never infinitival, though relatives without a relative word can be. And in usage the form of *whoever* answers to the function inside the clause as well as to the

[1] As in *CGEL*, * marks an unacceptable form, ? a questionable one, ! a non-standard one, and % one found only in some varieties.

function of the whole phrase. Fusion gets all three from the rules for relative clauses with a relative phrase, where the head analysis needs licences no other head has. So fusion is favoured there, though not forced, and it's the one construction where this paper keeps it.

2 Two analyses and a criterion

The framework keeps categories apart from functions. A category is a set of words or phrases, such as noun, determinative, or adjective. A function is the relation a constituent bears within its phrase, such as head, determiner, or modifier. The two vary independently: *nylon* is a noun functioning as head in *made of* [*nylon*] and as modifier in *a* [*nylon*] *shirt* (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 421), and an NP functions as determiner in [*Kim's*] *book*.

So DETERMINATIVE names a category (*the*, *this*, *some*, *every*, *many*), and DETERMINER names a function.[2] Figure 1a gives *CGEL*'s structure for *some apples*. The determinative heads a determinative phrase (DP) that functions as determiner (Det) of the NP.[3] The noun heads the NOMINAL (Nom), the unit between noun and NP, and the nominal is the NP's head. *CGEL* recognizes the unit because *old man* in *the old man* is neither a noun nor an NP, since it can't function as subject or object (p. 329). I write "nominal" in prose and Nom in trees and quotations. The NP's ULTIMATE HEAD is the word reached by following head relations down from the NP: *apples* in Figure 1a, *some* in b and c.

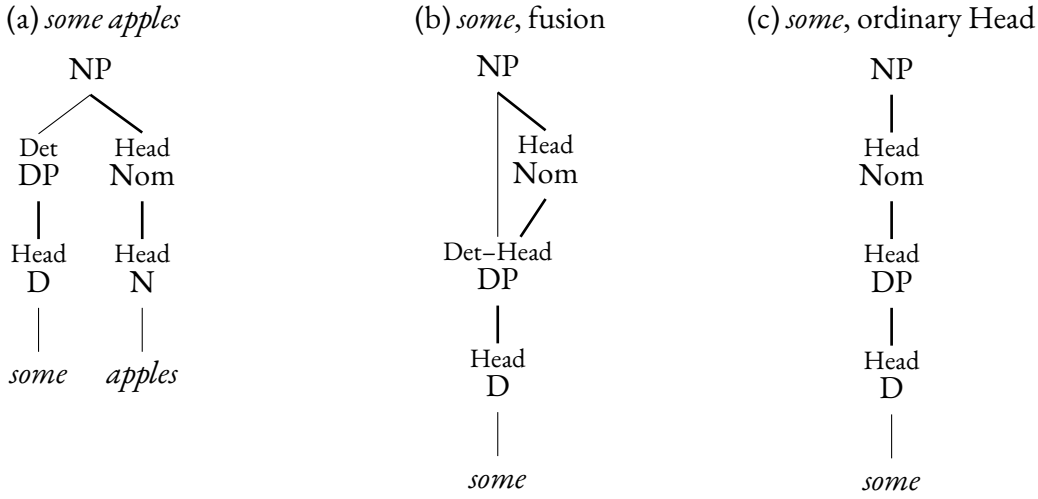


Figure 1: *Some apples* (a), and *some* standing alone under fusion (b) and ordinary Head (c). Function labels sit above category labels, and thick lines join heads to their parents. In (b) the DP has two parents, with a line from the NP for its determiner function and one from the nominal for its head function. In (c) it's the head of the nominal and nothing else. Each tree shows the DP even where it contains only D, so that the same constituent appears in all three.

[2] One more function is used from Section 3 on. A PERIPHERAL MODIFIER modifies a whole NP, determiner included, as *even* does in [*even*] *this house* (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 331).

[3] DP here is *CGEL*'s determinative phrase, a phrase whose head is a determinative, not the DP of the DP hypothesis, on which the determinative heads the whole noun phrase. Miller and Pullum (2022) draw the same distinction. Payne et al. (2007, 566 n. 2), like *CGEL*, take the noun as head of the NP.

Without a noun, as in *I'll take* [*some*], the nominal still needs a head. *CGEL*'s answer is FUSION OF FUNCTIONS: the DP functions as determiner and as head at once, a fused determiner-head (Det–Head; Figure 1b) (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 410–421). After a determiner, as in *the lucky few*, the word is a fused modifier-head (Mod–Head). Payne et al. (2007) make the device explicit and list where English uses it: "The subtypes of dependent involved are determiner, modifier and, in fused relative clauses, subject or prenucleus" (p. 571). Sections 3, 4 and 7 take them in that order, and Section 5 takes Payne et al.'s own case, *once*, *twice*, and *thrice*.

Fusion, as Payne et al. define it, departs from canonical structure in two ways. First, one constituent has two functions, so that it "will in effect have two mothers", which they call "the major departure from canonical principles of structure" (p. 570). The structure is then a directed acyclic graph rather than a tree (Pullum & Rogers, 2008), and the CGELBank treebank gives such a constituent a hyphenated label for its two parents (Reynolds et al., 2025, §3.2). In Det–Head the shared DP has two parents, the NP and the nominal; in Mod–Head both functions belong to one nominal (pp. 582, 588). Second, an NP can have an ultimate head of another category: the fused node is "a point in the normal path of headedness at which there can be a change of category" (p. 569).

ORDINARY HEAD keeps the second departure and drops the first. Whatever phrase *CGEL* fuses functions as head of the nominal and nothing else: a DP for *some* (Figure 1c) and for *few* in *the lucky few*, an AdjP in *the rich*. For adjectives this is close to the traditional analysis, though there the adjective heads the noun phrase itself: "Adjectives can function as heads of noun phrases" (Quirk et al., 1985, p. 421). A determiner before it, as *the* in *the rich*, is the NP's determiner as usual, and the nominal keeps its other dependents: in *few of them* the *of* -phrase is a complement in the nominal headed by *few*, as in *CGEL*'s own partitive tree (pp. 411–412). What fusion states as a licence for a fused function, ordinary Head states as a PERMISSION: a word may head a nominal, with or without a determiner before it. *Some* may head one with no determiner, and *rich* one after *the*.

CGEL has a term for a head of this kind: the independent genitive pronouns "occur in fused heads and also pure heads" (p. 410), a pure head being one with no second function. It also considers the analysis, as "change of function without change of category", with *many* a determiner in [*Many*] *people would agree with you* and a head in [*Many*] *would agree with you* (p. 421).

The change of category needs no new kind of structure. Payne et al. say it "will be independently required in the case of hybrid constructions" (p. 571), and their tree for *there's* [*no stopping him*] has a VP as head of an NP whose determiner is *no*: "an unexpected category appears as head … However, there is no fusion of functions in this case" (p. 600). The tree shares the two properties that matter here, an unexpected category as head and no constituent with two functions, though the VP heads the NP directly, with no nominal between. Payne et al. find hybrids "only marginally in English" (p. 566). But ordinary Head changes category in exactly the constructions where fusion does, at the same node, so it uses no departure that fusion doesn't also use, and uses it no more widely.

Both analyses keep three commitments that *CGEL* argues for, and the comparison holds them fixed. First, where an NP has a noun, the noun is its head, and the determinative is a dependent, as in *some apples*. Second, the determinative keeps its category when it stands alone: it takes the dependents it takes before a noun (*not much cheese*, *not much of the cheese*), which "argues against any part-of-speech distinction between the two uses" (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 420). Third, there's no silent head noun. Analyses that give up one of these avoid fusion by other means: a determiner phrase

headed by the determinative, or a silent noun.[4] This paper doesn't take those analyses on. Its result is conditional: given *CGEL*'s commitments, the evidence favours fusion only in fused relatives.

Since both analyses describe the same strings, the comparison needs a criterion. What they disagree about is structure, so the evidence that can decide between them is form, and *CGEL* itself takes form as the sign of a function when it argues from the genitive (p. 420). Payne et al. call a constituent with two functions a departure from canonical structure, so I take the burden to lie with the second function. Where the same category and head relation account for an expression, a property of form counts as evidence for a second function if it varies with that function and not with the word alone. By form I mean the shape of words (a case form, or a form like *none* that, in an NP, occurs only standing alone), order, and which dependents and determiners a word takes. Interpretation alone isn't form. *CGEL* keeps the two apart elsewhere. In *She considered Ed* [*quite competent*], the adjective phrase is predicated of *Ed*, which is the object of *considered*, and *CGEL* calls *Ed* the adjective phrase's PREDICAND, a semantic relation, not its subject, a syntactic one (pp. 217, 252).

The criterion answers *CGEL*'s one objection to ordinary Head. *Nylon* in *I prefer cotton shirts to* [*nylon*] is one of *CGEL*'s fused modifier-heads, of the type denoting composition (p. 417). *CGEL* rejects analysing it as a noun functioning simply as head, since that "would not distinguish this construction from *I prefer cotton to nylon*", where *nylon* isn't "understood as having modifier function" (p. 421). The difference is real. But the word is the same in both sentences, and so is its form: bare *nylon* as the object of *to*. What differs is what the context supplies.

The one formal property *CGEL* ties to these modifier-heads is their determiners. The NPs of *nylon*'s type "are either bare or have a definite determiner", with "significant loss of acceptability when the determiner is indefinite" (p. 417), and nouns of other types are excluded, as in **Bill likes the linguistics lecturer, but I prefer* [*the sociology*] (p. 415). The examples in (1) cross both lines.

(1) a. *You take the cat shirt and I'll take* [*the dog*].
b. **You take the cat shirt and I'll take* [*dog*].
c. *You take the cotton shirt and I'll take* [*nylon*].
d. *punishing people convicted of drug possession with a misdemeanor sentence rather than* [*a felony*] (*Arizona Daily Star*, 2019, COCA)

Dog and *felony* belong to no type *CGEL* lists, and they work. Bare *dog* is out and *a felony* is fine, as for a singular count noun generally. Non-count *nylon* stands bare for a single item and resists *a* (?*I bought a cotton shirt rather than* [*a nylon*], p. 417). So the determiners follow the noun's own countability. Both analyses make the noun the head, so both predict that. A silent head doesn't: every antecedent in (1) is a count noun, so a head that took its features would reject bare *nylon*, and a head

[4] On the DP hypothesis the determinative heads the phrase (see Miller & Pullum, 2022; Salzmann, 2020), and pronouns can be analysed as determiners (Postal, 1966); Payne et al. find that it makes an appropriate analysis of *once* hard to find (p. 566 n. 2). A silent noun is recovered from an antecedent on ellipsis analyses (Lobeck, 1995) and needs none on empty-noun analyses (Kester, 1996; Panagiotidis, 2003; Saab, 2019). Kayne (2007) gives *few* a silent NUMBER, and Aarts (2024) proposes empty heads in place of fusion. Wu (2021) puts an empty noun after *the rich* and after a determinative standing alone, rejecting adjective and determinative heads because a head should share its phrase's category and a bare adjective can't show number (pp. 19–20, 118, 173). Ordinary Head makes the adjective head of the nominal, not of the NP, and *the rich* is plural with no plural ending on every analysis, as Wu grants (p. 118 n. 14). *CGEL*'s grounds against a silent head are that partitives have no noun to restore (**many ones of us*), that *the rich* is generic and *the rich people* isn't, and that the construction lacks the marks of gapping (pp. 420–421).

with none of its own wouldn't exclude bare *dog*. What the facts don't show is anything that varies with the modifier function, and the restriction *CGEL* states for it doesn't hold.[5] On this criterion, nothing here counts as evidence for the modifier function.[6]

CGEL also names a form that a second function would show. A fused determiner-head should resist the genitive, because "for full acceptability its case should match both functions" (p. 420), and *CGEL* points to case in fused relatives, where the form of *whoever* or *whomever* reflects its function inside the relative clause (pp. 1073–1074). That's a test the later sections can run. Among fused determiner-heads, *either's* is fine and *many's* all but absent, though *CGEL* gives both words the same two functions (Section 3). After a preposition, *whomever* is chosen far more often when it isn't the subject of the relative clause, though its function in the main clause stays the same (Section 7). The first difference follows the word, the second the function.

The criterion says what counts as evidence for a second function, not how much is enough. A fact counts if the word alone doesn't explain it. Whether it outweighs the extra structure is a separate question, and a fact that something else could also explain weighs less. So the later sections compare the analyses construction by construction: what each predicts, where the data go against a prediction, what each has to state instead, and what the extra structure buys. Where the data can't separate the analyses, I say so, since finding no evidence for a second function isn't finding evidence against it. The standard also applies to what this paper adds. Its analysis of *a few* rests on number and on the structure of numerals (Section 4), and the licences ordinary Head needs for fused relatives count against it (Section 7).

A note on data. Examples are *CGEL*'s or Payne et al.'s where cited, attested where a source is given, and otherwise constructed. Judgments not attributed to a source are mine. Corpus lines come from COCA, the Corpus of News on the Web (NOW; Davies, 2016–present), and the iWeb corpus (Davies, 2018), searched by hand at english-corpora.org in September and October 2026; where a display was capped, counts are of the lines shown. Some sets of lines were classified by a large language model (Claude Opus 5.5), and each line's label is kept so that the classification can be checked. The model labelled the genitive lines in Section 3 twice, in separate runs, the second without access to the first's labels, and the two runs found the same genitives. I checked the labels behind Sections 3 and 7 by hand (for the earlier searches, a sample of 106) and changed five. The record behind each corpus claim, with its query, date, counts, and labels (but not the corpus lines), is listed in an evidence index.

3 Determinatives standing alone: Det–Head

A determinative can make up a whole noun phrase, or head one that also contains a complement or modifier, and so can an independent genitive such as *mine* (e):

(2) a. *I'll take* [*some*].

[5] Dependents give the same result. Matthews (2014, pp. 28–29) notes that material nouns used as modifiers take *partly* and *largely* (*a partly cotton shirt*) and suggests they're adjectives there. But uses with no modifier function take them too (*I prefer cotton to* [*partly nylon*]; *This lava is* [*partly magma*], conserve-energy-future.com), so *partly* isn't tied to the modifier function.

[6] *CGEL*'s other example, *Mary earns* [*double*] (p. 421), fuses a noun with a predeterminer modifier (p. 418), and *double* gets the treatment *nylon* gets. Its category fits. Before a definite determiner, *CGEL*'s predeterminers are nouns and NPs (*half the cake*, *double the number of applications*) or the adverb *twice* (p. 434), and my searches of the Corpus of Contemporary American English (COCA; Davies, 2008–present) found no adjective phrase there, apart from one marginal *400-fold the amount* (a blog, 2012).

b. [*Few*] *would dare underestimate Aaron Finch's men.*
c. *some of the wine*, *many of them*, *whichever of them*
d. *hardly anyone present*, *something reliable*
e. [*Mine*] *are ready.*

For *CGEL* each of these has a fused Det–Head: one phrase functions at once as determiner of the NP and as head of its nominal (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 410–423). On ordinary Head it's a pure head, with no second function (Section 2). The question here is whether anything in the form of these expressions shows the determiner function.

Some things aren't at issue. Both analyses take these to be complete NPs with no silent noun. They have the functions of NPs (*Some left*, *I see some*, *with some*), there's no noun to restore (**many ones of us*; pp. 420–421), and often there's none in the context either.[7] Nor is the lack of a further determiner evidence for the determiner function. *CGEL* gives *She left*, *Kim left*, and *People left* NPs with no determiner, and ordinary Head gives *Some left* the same structure.

Partitives add nothing here. In *some of the wine*, the *of* -phrase is a complement inside the nominal (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 411–412), so *some* is the ultimate head on either analysis. The claim about bare uses extends to them unchanged, including *whichever of them* in the fused relative of Section 7. So do relative clauses.[8]

CGEL and Payne et al. (2007) point to three places where the determiner function might show: the correspondence with the determiner use; the forms of *none*, *mine*, and the compounds; and case. None of them shows it. One fact of distribution does favour fusion, and it comes with the compounds.

First, the correspondence. *CGEL* keeps the determiner function because the word "can occur in the dependent position in NPs where it is not fused with the head" (p. 410). It keeps the category because the word takes the same dependents in both uses (*not much cheese*, *not much of the cheese*; pp. 420–421). Ordinary Head keeps the category, and with it both facts: *much* is the same determinative in both uses, and it takes the dependents a determinative takes.

What the correspondence adds beyond the category is a list of the determinatives that can stand alone. *Some*, *each*, and *either* can, and *every* normally can't (**every of the students*), though NOW has two published lines with it standing alone, whose status I leave open (*Every has a story*, *Patch*, 2025; *Every has different blocking mechanics*, *Guardian*, 2024); *no* does so only in the form *none*. Payne et al. (2007, p. 581) state the list as a "lexical distinction between determinatives that allow [fusion of functions] and those that do not". Ordinary Head states the same list as a permission to head a nominal with no determiner. Neither analysis gets it free.

CGEL considers ordinary Head too, as "change of function without change of category", and rejects it because *nylon* in *I prefer cotton shirts to* [*nylon*] is "understood as having modifier function"

[7] Of 94 NOW lines for *few would*, 82 have no noun phrase or named set in the displayed context that could supply the set, as in (2b) (*Daily Times*, Pakistan, 20 October 2022); 3 have one, 2 probably do, and 7 can't be decided from the window.

[8] Wu (2021, pp. 184–185) finds a dilemma for fusion in *For* [*some who made the journey into Wales*]*, the experience was profound* (BNC): fusion makes *some*, a determiner, the antecedent of the relative clause, against the principle that determiners don't count as antecedents, and he adds an empty noun to resolve it. On ordinary Head, *some* heads the nominal and the relative clause modifies that nominal, with nothing added.

(p. 421). Section 2 answers that objection: an interpretation alone doesn't establish a syntactic function. For determinatives the objection has a further gap. It contrasts a word's use as a pure head with its fused use, and *CGEL* gives determinatives no use as a pure head.

Second, form. Payne et al. find formal differences between fused and non-fused functions here, as in fused relatives: *no* "has a specialized morphological variant *none* which is restricted to the fused function" (p. 581). A difference of form doesn't say which function it marks, though, and the genitive pronouns supply the test. They alternate the same way (*my*, *mine*), and *CGEL* states the conditioning for both pairs at once: "the dependent forms are used in (pure) determiner function, the independent ones in head function" (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 410).

Mine occurs with a determiner function and without one. The independent genitive pronouns "occur in fused heads and also pure heads" (p. 410), pure heads being heads with no second function, and predicative *mine* in *Everything that is* [*mine*] *is yours* has "no basis for a fused-head analysis" (p. 469). Its form is the same, so the form marks the head function. *None* has no pure-head use to test (p. 410), so its form is assigned to the same conditioning on the model of *mine*, not shown independently. Ordinary Head then states both alternations as *CGEL* does, by function: Det against Head.

Compounds raise the question of form again. *CGEL* analyses *anyone*, *something*, and the rest as fused determiner-heads (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 423). Payne et al. take them to be determinatives because "they take exactly the same pre-head modifiers as the determinative bases they contain" (p. 581): *not everything* beside *not every house*, *hardly anyone present* beside *hardly any writer present*. That fixes the category, which ordinary Head keeps.

On ordinary Head, *not* and *hardly* are modifiers of the whole NP, the kind *CGEL* calls peripheral (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 430–431), and the compound's base still decides which ones it takes. Payne et al. also take the compounds' morphology, a determinative base with a nominal base, to mirror fusion (pp. 565, 587–588). What the two bases mirror is the compound's meaning, a quantifier with a sort ('person', 'thing'), and both analyses give it that meaning. Simple *some* and *few* have no nominal base, and for Payne et al. they're fused just the same.[9]

The compounds' modifiers divide by side: adverbs before, adjectives after (*hardly anyone present*, *something reliable*). The adjective is a RESTRICTOR, a single post-head dependent that doesn't recur and can be a simple adjective, of the kind that would normally precede a noun (p. 423; Payne et al., 2007, p. 583). Payne et al. count fusion's account of the division "a particular strength" (p. 583). On ordinary Head the compound, as head of the nominal, takes the restrictor inside the nominal, and the grouping differs: ordinary Head gives [*hardly* [*anyone present*]], fusion [[*hardly anyone*] *present*].

CGEL's peripheral modifiers can scope over a whole NP, as in *After* [*hardly a moment's hesitation*] *he agreed* (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 437), so a fusion grammar can assign the first grouping too, and the grouping doesn't decide between them.

Nor does fusion account for the restrictor's position by itself. *CGEL* puts the adjective after the head "because determiner and head are fused", which rules out pre-head dependents (p. 423). But the restrictor stays where nothing is fused. *CGEL* treats *something* in *a little something* as a noun formed by conversion (p. 423 n. 43), and a single adjective follows it (*a little something extra*), as one does in *a pre-emptive something fabulous* (CBS, 2007). With a common noun as head, a postpositive adject-

[9] Payne et al.'s own note treats the nominal base of *once* as a reanalysis of a genitive ending (p. 588 n. 30); see Section 5.

ive occurs only "under restricted conditions" (p. 529).[10] So the position goes with the compound, whatever its functions. A defender of fusion can let the converted noun inherit the compound's restrictor, but that's a statement about the word, of the kind ordinary Head makes for every use. The division gives fusion no advantage, then, though it gives ordinary Head none either.

The other half of the division does favour fusion, and it's the one trace of the determiner function in the distribution of these words. Bare determinatives take no pre-head adjective (**nice anyone*, **Lucky few escaped*), apart from a few exclamations such as *Poor everybody!* (Section 4). With the determiner and head functions fused, an adjective would have to come before the determiner, so fusion derives the gap from adjacency, where ordinary Head has to state it, as an analysis with a silent head does (Payne et al., 2007, p. 584).

The adjective is fine once a determiner precedes (*the lucky few*). It's also fine in *a lucky few*, which *CGEL*'s analyses of *a few* allow two ways (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 353, 392). Section 4 shows that on either way the adjective doesn't come before a bare determinative, so the gap stands.

Third, case, where *CGEL* itself says the determiner function would show. In *many people's expenses*, the genitive *'s* attaches to *people*, the head of *many people's*, and not to its determiner, *many*. On the fused analysis a bare *many* is both head and determiner, so **many's expenses* would put the genitive on a determiner. *CGEL* reports that very gap, calling *all's*, *many's*, *few's*, and *some's* "completely excluded". Its explanation is fusion: "the form is simultaneously determiner and head, and for full acceptability its case should match both functions" (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 420).

CGEL offers this against analysing these words as pronouns, an analysis that gives no reason for the gap (p. 420). Ordinary Head gives no reason either, so the argument bears on it too, and it's the most direct of the three.

For *all*, *many*, *few*, and *some*, the gap is all but complete in usage,[11] but it doesn't hold across the fused determiner-heads. *Either's*, *neither's*, and *each's* occur in edited prose, and I find them acceptable: *won't substantially increase* [*either's*] *share of its market* (*TIME*, 2000), [*Neither's*] *numbers are all that encouraging* (*Washington Post*, 2014), *the highlight of* [*each's*] *day* (*Atlantic*, 1995). *CGEL* calls *each's* "occasionally attested but of somewhat questionable status" (p. 420). COCA's twelve genitives of *each* fit the first half of that, but five of them are in edited prose, which fits the second less well.

CGEL's own examples of genitive marking on the head include *everyone's* and *somebody's* (p. 479), compounds it analyses as fused determiner-heads (p. 423). A defender of fusion could put their genitive down to the nominal base, *-one* or *-body*.

[10] In COCA (18 October 2026), 46 of 50 lines with an article, an adjective, *somebody* or *something*, and a second adjective have it after *something*: 43 *a little something* (*extra* in most), plus *a certain something special* (cafnrnews.com, 2012), *a pre-emptive something fabulous*, and *a special something unique to* … (1996), whose adjective phrase has a complement and would follow any head (p. 445). The evidence beyond the formula is thin, and none has a personal compound. *Else* survives in the same frame (*a certain someone else*, *Community*, 2010), but *CGEL* doesn't derive it from fusion, since *all*, *much*, and *little* take it too (p. 423).

[11] COCA searches for each word followed by *'s*, one search per word, give the following genitives on the word standing alone, out of the lines each search returned: *either* 17 of 30 lines, *neither* 6 of 23, *each* 12 of 12, *many* 3 of 76, *some* 1 of 24, *few* none of 22, and *all* none in a display-capped sample of 499 lines (nine genitives there are on *you all*). The other lines are mostly contractions of *is* or *has* (*Either's fine*, *many's the time*) and names. The counts aren't adjusted for how often each word stands alone. Thirteen of the 35 genitives of *either*, *neither*, and *each* come from edited prose (fiction, magazines, newspapers, academic writing). The four of *many* and *some* all come from the web; two seem fine to me (*to* [*many's*] *suprise* [sic] *he won*, *out of* [*so many's*] *reach*), the other two questionable.

So the genitive divides these words, and the argument from case faces a dilemma. If *many's* is out because its case would have to match two functions (p. 420), then *either's*, *neither's*, and *each's* should be out too, since *CGEL* gives those words the same two functions. If something else keeps *many's* out, the gap is no evidence for the determiner function. Either way, the two functions don't predict where the division falls, though that doesn't show that function plays no part. As stated, neither analysis predicts it: fusion has to exempt *either*, *neither*, *each*, and the compounds unless their nominal base carries the genitive, and ordinary Head has to list the words that don't take it, as it lists the reflexive pronouns, which have no genitive either (p. 426).

The division may follow meaning. The words that take the genitive, the compounds included, are singular, and those that don't are words of quantity (*all*, *many*, *few*, *some*); if that's what decides, neither analysis needs a list. Either way, what the form varies with is the word, not its functions. A comparison that could show a function would keep the word and change its functions, and for these words there's none to make, since *CGEL* gives them no use as a pure head.

Section 7 finds that kind of evidence. After a preposition, *whomever* is chosen over *whoever* far more often when it isn't the subject of the relative clause than when it is. The word and its function in the main clause stay the same, and the form follows the function inside the relative clause. On the diagnostic *CGEL* itself proposes, then, the determiner function doesn't show in fused determiner-heads, and the second function in fused relatives does.

Both analyses, then, list the same words and forms. The trade is a constituent with two functions against one stated condition on pre-head adjectives, of a kind the grammar already states for pronouns (Section 4). Apart from the pre-head adjective, nothing in the form of these expressions shows a determiner function. That fact is a real advantage for fusion, and Section 6 weighs it against what ordinary Head gains.

4 Modifiers as heads: Mod–Head

In Mod–Head fusion the head of a nominal is also its modifier. *CGEL* uses it for words that function elsewhere as modifiers in a nominal: determinatives and adjectives, and also nouns such as *nylon* (p. 417), taken up in Section 2:[12]

(3) a. *This copy is defective but* [*the other two*] *are fine.*
b. *I didn't like it myself, but I respect the views of* [*the many who did*].
c. *Are you one of* [*the lucky few who found powdered infant formula*]*?*
d. [*The rich*] *cannot enter the kingdom of Heaven.*
e. *How will the new system affect* [*the very poor*]*?*
f. *There were two pieces left and Kim, as always, chose* [*the larger*].

For *CGEL*, *two*, *many*, *few*, *rich*, *poor*, and *larger* each modify the nominal and head it at once (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 415–419). Payne et al. (2007, pp. 579–580) draw the adjectival case for *the very hard of hearing*: the AdjP is "head of Nom" and "modifier of that head", and *the*

[12] Examples (3a, b, d–f) are *CGEL*'s (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 416–419); (3c) is from NOW (*National Observer*, 3 October 2022).

is the NP's determiner as usual.[13] Unlike Det–Head, both functions belong to the same nominal (p. 588; Figure 2). Their main Mod–Head case, *this once*, is taken up in Section 5. On ordinary Head the phrase is the head of the nominal and nothing more.

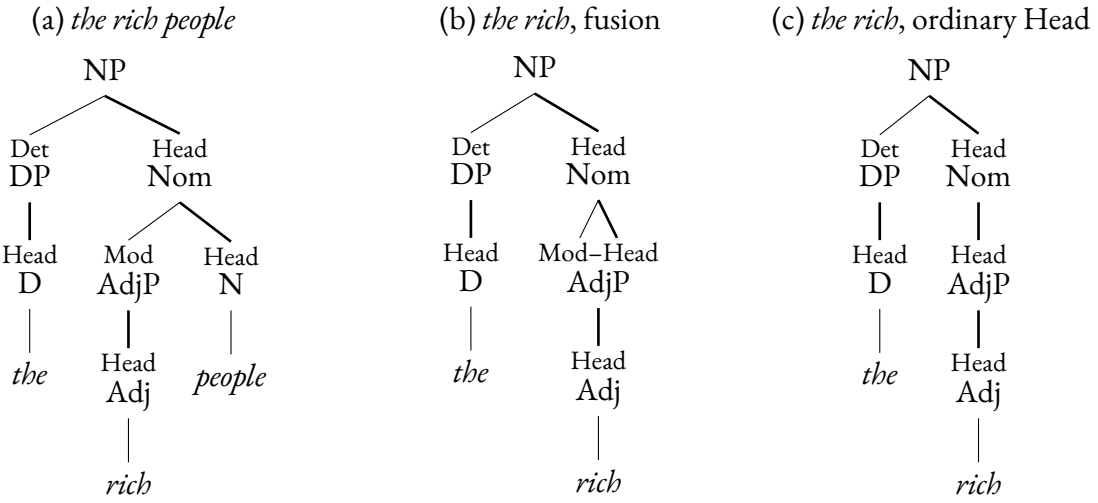


Figure 2: *The rich people* (a), and *the rich* under fusion (b) and ordinary Head (c). In (b) the AdjP has one parent, the nominal, with a line from it for each of its two functions; in Figure 1b the fused DP has two parents. In (c) the AdjP is the head of the nominal and nothing else.

So the two analyses agree that the adjective or determinative heads the nominal. Neither has a noun as the NP's ultimate head, the change of category Payne et al. accept at the fused node (p. 569). Both keep the word's category. *Rich* and *poor* take adverbs (*the extremely rich*, *the very poor*), which *CGEL* calls "clear evidence that they retain their category status as adjectives", and *the rich* is plural with no plural ending (p. 418). Both give the head the dependents it takes elsewhere: a partitive in *the biggest of them* (p. 416), a post-head phrase in *the pure in heart* (p. 418). *Few* takes the same partitive with a determiner and without one (*few of them*, *the few of us who stayed*), so the dependents don't separate the Det–Head use from the Mod–Head one either. And neither restores a noun: *the people very hard of hearing* can't be read generically, as *the very hard of hearing* is (Payne et al., 2007, p. 580).

What's at issue is only the second function, the modifier. Form could show it in two ways: a form restricted to the fused function, as *none* is for Det–Head, or a fact of order that only a modifier relation predicts. The formal differences Payne et al. cite are in Det–Head and in fused relatives (*none*, p. 581; the *-ever* forms, p. 576), and they cite none for Mod–Head. Their fact of order is adjacency: nothing comes between the fused functions, so **the in the room very hard of hearing* is out (p. 580 n. 17). That argument is aimed at a silent head. With the AdjP as head, the PP would precede the head of a nominal, which PPs don't do before a noun either (**the in the room people*).

For determinatives, *CGEL* links the fused use to the dependent one. Determinatives "which can function as internal modifier as well as determiner can in general occur as fused modifier-head as well as determiner-head" (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 415): *the few* beside *the few mistakes*, where

[13] Payne et al.'s tree labels the fused function Head-Mod, since the counterpart modifier follows the head (*people very hard of hearing*); their tree for *this once* has Mod-Head (p. 588). *CGEL* allows fusion with a post-head modifier as well (p. 418). I write Mod–Head for both.

few is modifier (p. 392). Payne et al. (2007, p. 588) state the link without the hedge: *some*, *every*, *any*, and *no* "can function solely as determiners and therefore never permit a preceding determiner".

Yet *some* is attested after *the*, if marginally: *when times are bad,* [*the some*] *will become the many*; *one of* [*the some who hope for a return to the good old days*].[14] With *the* as determiner, a fused *some* can only be a modifier-head, and that's the Mod–Head Payne et al.'s "never" excludes. *CGEL*'s licence is hedged, and it records exceptions of both kinds itself. *Both*, which "cannot occur in internal modifier function", heads a nominal after *the* in *the both of us* (p. 377). *Every* and *various* function as modifiers after a determiner (*her every move*, *the various options*) but don't head a nominal there: "*Every* is again excluded, and so too this time is *various*" (p. 416).

So the link between the two uses is a default, not a condition. A determinative that functions as modifier after a determiner can usually head a nominal after one too, but the exceptions run both ways, and both analyses list the determinatives that can. Fusion does build one direction into the structure: a fused modifier-head is a modifier, so a word with no modifier use shouldn't head a nominal after a determiner. But *the some* and *the both of us* are exceptions in just that direction, and the other direction (*every*, *various*) is a list on both analyses. Ordinary Head states the list as a permission, as it states the list of determinatives that stand alone (Section 3). Both also need *CGEL*'s observation that, cardinals apart, these determinatives are "hardly admissible" after a determiner unless the NP has a post-head modifier, as in *these few here* and *the many who did* (p. 416). That holds where *few* and *many* pick out part of a set given in the context. Read as 'few people' or 'many people', they stand alone after *the*, as *the rich* does.

The some also tells against a silent noun (Section 2): one would make *some* in *the some* [N] *who say it* a modifier after *the*, which Payne et al. exclude (p. 588), and none of 50 iWeb lines of *the some people* has that reading.

The determiners these heads take follow the word too. With an adjective before independent *few*, the determiner is *the* in 192 of 321 COCA lines, and a demonstrative (*those chosen few*), a genitive (*Hollywood's chosen few*), *some*, *we*, or *us* in 35; nearly all the rest have *a*, which belongs to the DP, as argued below.[15] All of these are also determiners in NPs headed by plural nouns. The adjectives of the *rich* type take *the* or a genitive (*the world's poor*, *our elderly*), though *CGEL* says they're "determined by the definite article" and adds that "we couldn't even substitute a demonstrative: **these very poor*"

[14] COCA: *Foreign Affairs*, 1999; iWeb: sspnet.org. COCA has five clear lines across searches for `the some`, `the some who`, and `the some of us who`; the other hits on the first display page of `the some` are typos for *same*, the adverb *some* 'approximately', titles, and garbled text. iWeb has 10 hits for `the some who`, most with no earlier *some* in view, so they aren't quotations of the word.

[15] COCA, searched by hand for *lucky*, *chosen*, *fortunate*, *remaining*, and *priveledged* (sic) before *few*: 607 tokens, 368 lines inspected, 321 with no following noun. Of the 321, 192 have *the*, 90 *a* alone, 25 a demonstrative, 6 a genitive, 2 *some*, and 2 *we* or *us*; one is a name, and three have nothing before the adjective (a headline, a fragment, and a web post). With a preposition directly before the adjective, COCA has only headlines and blog posts (*Asylum for* [*Lucky Few*], *New York Times*, 1991). iWeb has 92 such tokens, 66 of them *select few*, often before a noun (*teleconverters only work with* [*select few*] *lenses*), and 17 of NOW's 22 bare tokens of *only select few* are from Indian sources. But NOW also has ordinary adjectives in the frame (*the group of* [*vicious few*] *who are driven by self-interest*, legit.ng, 2020), most of them from Nigerian and Indian sources, where COCA has a single blog post. So what differs there is more likely the article than *few*: the gap holds where an NP of this kind needs a determiner, and on both analyses these NPs lack one.

(Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 417).[16] Among adjectives, *blue* takes no determiner and *second* takes *a* (pp. 416–417), and both analyses state the range word by word, or type by type.

What ordinary Head adds is one structure for every use of *few*: *few would dare*, *few of them*, *the few*, and *the lucky few*. In each, *few* heads the nominal, and a determiner, when there's one, is the NP's own. Fusion gives the first two Det–Head and the last two Mod–Head, so the same word heading the same kind of NP gets a different pair of functions depending on whether a determiner precedes it.

Which adjectives can head a nominal is a list on both analyses. *CGEL* gives types, such as superlatives (*the tallest*), ordinals (*the second*), colours (*I like* [*blue*]), and the special interpretation of *the rich* (pp. 416–417), and excludes **the advancing* (p. 415), **a bigger*, and **the main* (p. 416). *Main* is attributive-only (p. 558), so modifier is its only function, and its exclusion is *CGEL*'s evidence that "the possibility of fusion with the head must in the last resort be stated in syntactic terms" (p. 416). Ordinary Head states the same list, as permissions to head a nominal. Generality is also *CGEL*'s argument against traditional grammar, which calls *several* a pronoun in [*several*] *look quite promising* and treats *the larger* as elliptical. Against that split, *CGEL* holds that "a unitary treatment is to be preferred on grounds of simplicity and generality" (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 419), and fusion provides one. Ordinary Head keeps the gain with a single function: each word heads its nominal. Fusion gives the two words different pairs, Det–Head and Mod–Head.

Case shows no modifier function either. *CGEL*'s argument from the genitive concerns the determiner function (p. 420), and it states no case requirement for modifiers, so the check here is this paper's own: whether the genitive divides the fused modifier-heads as it divides the determiner-heads (Section 3). It does. *The latter's* and *the former's* are frequent, *the poor's* occurs in edited prose ([*the poor's*] *material well-being has improved*, *Newsweek*, 2010), *the rich's* only on the web, and *few* after a determiner almost never.[17] In these lines too, the division follows the word.

Mod–Head is also where the advantage Section 3 conceded to fusion has to be weighed. A bare determinative takes no pre-head adjective outside a few exclamations, taken up below (**Lucky few escaped*),[18] and fusion derives the gap from adjacency: with *few* as Det–Head, *lucky* would have to precede the determiner. After *the*, *few* is Mod–Head and *lucky* modifies the nominal it heads. Ordinary Head states a condition: a determinative heading a nominal takes a pre-head adjective only when the NP has a determiner.

[16] In 500 COCA lines of `[apps*] poor|rich|elderly` (18 October 2026), 19 have the adjective heading the NP after a genitive pronoun (*care for* [*their elderly*], *New York Times*, 1992).

[17] One COCA search for *the latter*, *the former*, *the other*, *the poor*, and *the rich* followed by *'s* displayed 500 lines, probably a cap (498 pasted). In those lines the genitives number 149 for *the latter*, 31 for *the former*, 8 for *the poor* (five in magazines and academic writing), and 3 for *the rich* (all web or blog). *CGEL* has one in its own prose: in its account of the traditional definition, a preposition "expresses the latter's relation to another word" (p. 598). *The other* has 253, set aside because its plural *others* leaves a noun analysis open. `the few/many 's` gave no genitive, and `few 's` one after a determiner, [*the first few's*] *salty freshness* (*Ploughshares*, 1996, fiction). A cardinal after a determiner takes the genitive freely: `those|the two 's` gives it in 21 of 34 lines, ten of them in edited prose ([*the two's*] *relationship gets worse the longer Rosberg leads the championship*, *New York Post*, 2016).

[18] *Precious few would dare* isn't an exception. For *precious* in *They had precious little money*, Matthews (2014, p. 102) offers the predicative use as the crucial evidence that it's an adverb (*The money they had left was precious little*), and the same test works for *few* (*Volunteers were precious few*). So *precious* is a modifier in the DP, as *very* is in *very few*, not in the nominal.

A lucky few looks like an exception for both. Of the 321 COCA lines with an adjective before independent *few*, 90 have *a* as the only word before the adjective, and where a verb agrees with the phrase, it's plural: [*a lucky few*] *were sent far and wide to schools in other counties and states* (*Washington Post*, 2015). The adjective can be a phrase (*A very lucky few*, CNN, 2005). *CGEL* has two analyses that could apply. In one, *a few* is a complex determinative whose internal structure is "sui generis", admitting *very*, *good*, and *fair*, and it's put among the lexical determinatives "as with the cardinal numerals" (p. 392). In the other, *a* begins a sequence such as *a further* or *a good*, which takes a plural head if a numeral or *few* quantifies it, as in [*A further few volunteers*] *were needed* (p. 353), and in *a marvellous hundred days* "*a* is determiner and quite independent of *hundred*" (p. 385 n. 26).

Neither analysis separates fusion from ordinary Head. If *a* is the determiner, *few* follows a determiner, as in *the lucky few*, and the adjective comes after it, so adjacency is undisturbed and ordinary Head's condition is met. If *a* belongs to the determinative, so does the adjective, which then precedes *few* inside the DP, not in the nominal. Either way the grammar needs a statement, a list of the sequences with *a* that take a plural head or a slot inside the determinative, and the statement is the same on both analyses.

I take the analysis on which *a* belongs to the determinative, in a form that gives *a good few* one analysis where *CGEL*'s two treatments would give it two (pp. 353, 392). In *a hundred days*, *CGEL* says that *a*, which replaces *one*, "must be considered as an integral part of the numeral, and not as an independent determiner", since "the whole NP is clearly plural, not singular, as it would be if *a* were the determiner" (p. 385). Reynolds (2026, pp. 7, 10) argues that numerals above 99 are phrases, with the factor (*one* in *one thousand*) a modifier of the magnitude word, and that other modifiers can come between them (*one whole thousand*). On that analysis, *a few* is a DP headed by *few*, with *a* as a modifier, and *a very few*, *a good few*, *a further few*, and *a lucky few* are the same DP with a modifier after *a* (Figure 3).[19] Before a noun the DP is the determiner (*a lucky few students*). On its own it heads the nominal, or for fusion is a Det–Head. *Quite* modifies it in *quite a few* (p. 392), and the NP is plural, as *a hundred days* is: on this analysis the plural is the head's own, where *CGEL*'s other route has to let these sequences with *a* take a plural head (p. 353). That the adjective comes only after *a*, as *whole* comes after the factor in *one whole thousand*, is stated on both analyses. So *a lucky few* no longer counts against either. Fusion's derivation of **Lucky few escaped* stands for *lucky* as a modifier in the nominal, and the statement both analyses make excludes it inside the DP.

[19] The slot is open. Besides *CGEL*'s *a good few* and *a fair few* (p. 392), COCA has at least 28 adjectives in it before a plural noun, in at least 123 tokens ([*a mere few*] *feet*, [*a paltry few*] *pages*, [*a harrowing few*] *quarters*). For *a great many*, *CGEL* allows *great* or *good* and says that "one or other of these adjectives is required" (p. 394), but COCA has ten others in that slot, one token each, as in *when a shrinking few do very well and* [*a growing many*] *barely make it* (NPR, 2013). *A few* is positive where *few* is negative (pp. 393–394), which I take to be a convention of the combination, as the minimizer reading of *a bit* is in *They didn't enjoy it* [*a bit*] (p. 725).

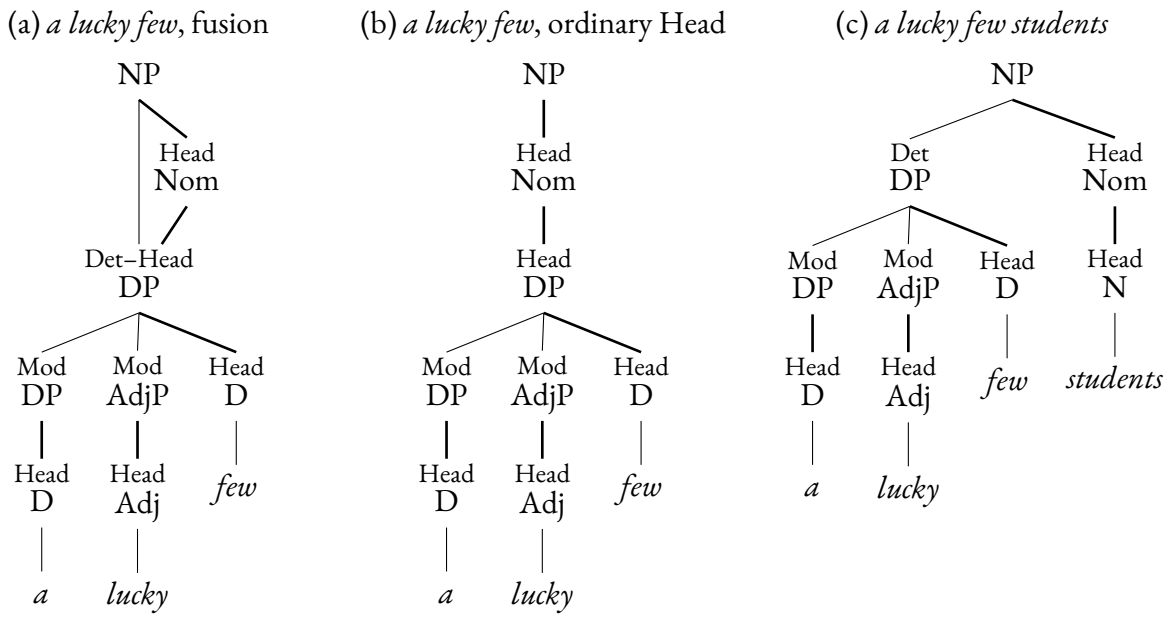


Figure 3: *A lucky few* under fusion (a) and ordinary Head (b), and *a lucky few students* (c), on the analysis adopted here. *A* and *lucky* are modifiers in the DP headed by *few*, as *one* and *whole* are to *thousand* in *one whole thousand*, so the adjective is neither before the determiner nor in the nominal.

For Payne et al. (2007, p. 584), a condition of this kind is "precisely the kind of stipulation which is not required when the determiner and head functions are fused". They say it of a silent-head analysis of the compounds, but it applies to ordinary Head's condition too. Whether the grammar needs such a statement anyway turns on the other heads with no determiner in their primary use, pronouns and names, and on three questions: whether such a head takes a pre-head dependent at all, whether it takes a non-restrictive adjective, and whether a restrictive one needs a determiner.

On the first, the grammar already makes a statement of this kind. Pronouns, which by definition "do not permit determiners" (p. 429), "do not normally allow internal pre-head dependents" (**Extravagant he bought a new car*, p. 430), though they take some after the head (*you who worked on both the projects*, p. 429). The compounds split the same way, and for them *CGEL* derives the gap from fusion (p. 423); a pronoun has no determiner function to derive it from. Ordinary Head's condition has to mention a determiner, as the pronouns' needn't, so fusion's derivation saves a statement, but not a kind of statement the grammar would otherwise lack.

On the second, names take a few non-restrictive adjectives with no determiner (*poor Henry*; pp. 520–521), and the core personal pronouns take *lucky*, *poor*, and *silly* (*Lucky you!*; p. 430). Simple determinatives don't seem to (**Lucky few!*, **Poor many!*), but two compounds are attested in the pronouns' exclamation, each just after the same exclamation with a name or a pronoun: *Poor Val. Poor everybody.* (*New Yorker*, 2005), *Lucky you. Lucky everyone.* (*Everwood*, 2004).[20] For *CGEL* these are fused determiner-heads, for which a pre-head dependent is "not possible" (p. 423). Fusion can call them

[20]COCA, 18 October 2026, `poor|lucky|silly everybody|everyone|somebody|someone`: these 2 of 28 lines; in the rest the adjective is predicative, comes before a clause (*You're lucky someone called it in*), or follows a determiner, and no line has *somebody* or *someone* in the use. NOW and iWeb have six more, four of them closing a series after a name or noun (*Poor Amy. Poor Deb.* [*Poor everyone*]., TV Fanatic, 2016).

nouns by conversion here, like *a nobody* (p. 423 n. 43), though they keep the compounds' meaning and take no determiner; list them as an exception; or take the adjective as a modifier of the whole NP, which separates them from *Lucky you!* (p. 430). On any of these, adjacency's derivation needs qualifying. Ordinary Head adds them to *CGEL*'s exception for "a few adjectives such as *lucky*, *poor*, *silly* with the core personal pronouns". So the exclamation needs further treatment on both analyses, and it doesn't separate them.

The third question is where pronouns and names look most like determinatives, but the likeness comes from countability. A restrictive adjective after a determiner is routine with personal pronouns (COCA has 350 tokens of *the real me*), and the NP is singular (*The real you is still alive back on Earth*, *Analog*, 2019).[21] *CGEL* would presumably call the word a common noun here, as it calls *he* and *she* in *Is it a he or a she?* (p. 429 n. 46), though the reflexive suggests a secondary use of the pronoun.[22] Names are the same: in *The young Isaac Newton showed no signs of genius*, *young* restricts a secondary use in which determiners are "selected in the ordinary way" (pp. 520–521). A singular count head needs a determiner, with or without a modifier. A plural head needs none, and takes a restrictive adjective without one, a plural name included (*Lucky survivors were airlifted out*, *Young Kennedys still go into politics*). So nothing that holds for names or for *the real me* predicts **Remaining few were the hangers-on* beside *The remaining few were the hangers-on* (*Christian Century*, 1998). Fusion's adjacency does.

So ordinary Head's condition is a further statement of a kind the grammar already contains, the exclamation needs further treatment on both analyses, and the facts with a determiner follow from number and countability. The pre-head adjective remains the one trace of the determiner function (Section 3), but its derivation saves less than Payne et al. suggest.

Nothing in the form of Mod–Head expressions, then, shows the modifier function. Which determinatives take an external determiner, which determiners they take, which adjectives head a nominal, and which heads take the genitive all follow the word, and both analyses list them. Fusion derives the absence of an adjective before a bare determinative, where ordinary Head states it, and *Poor everybody!* needs a further statement on both.

5 *Once*, *twice*, AND *thrice*

Payne et al. (2007) built their case for fusion on *once*, *twice*, and *thrice*. They distinguish five uses of *once*: numerical (*I will only say this to you once*), singulative (*Not once have I seen anything like this*), past (*I was once a teenage werewolf*), term of office (*the once mayor of New York*), and sequential, which they analyse as a preposition like *after*, with no fusion (pp. 584, 592, 594). *Twice* and *thrice* have the numerical and term-of-office uses, and a multiplier use (pp. 594–596).

Much of their argument concerns category. Against an adverb analysis, numerical *once* takes determiners and relative clauses, freely and not only in idioms (*four times for every once that the large pulley goes round*, p. 586 and n. 28), and it can function as subject (*Once is enough*, p. 587). Against the noun analysis of some dictionaries (p. 587), it takes the pre-head modifiers of *one*: *at least once* be-

[21] COCA, 15 October 2026: of the 14 lines for `the real you [be]`, ten have *the real you* as subject, all with *is* or *'s*.

[22] The reflexive keeps the pronoun's person (*The 12-year-old me is kicking myself*), as a common noun's doesn't (**Daddy is enjoying myself*), except that a stage of the speaker contrasted with another can take third-person forms (Halm, 2021, pp. 19, 29–30).

side *at least one time*, *more than once* beside *more than one time* (p. 589). It's a determinative, and on ordinary Head it heads the nominal of its NP, so what's in question is again only the second function.

They take the form of the word to show that function too. In *someone* and the other compound determinatives "the morphological compounding in this case reflects the fusion of two syntactic functions", and *once* is "similarly" a compound, of a determinative base *on·* and a noun base *·ce* 'time' (pp. 587–588). But simple *some* and *few* are fused with no compounding, and Payne et al.'s own note takes *·ce* to be a reanalysed genitive ending (p. 588 n. 30), and Wu (2021, p. 89) finds their noun base "far from convincing". What the two bases mirror is the word's meaning, a quantifier with a sort, as in the compounds (Section 3), and both analyses give *once* that meaning.

The first thing fusion is said to explain is why *once* occurs both with and without a determiner, which a singular count noun doesn't. Numerical *one* functions as determiner (*one time*) and as modifier after a determiner (*this one time*), so *once* is a fused determiner-head on its own and a fused modifier-head after *this* (p. 588). That's the link between the two uses that Section 4 examined for *few*, a default with exceptions both ways. Ordinary Head states it as a permission: *once* may head a nominal with or without a determiner.

The second is the adjective. Since the fused *once* is also the determiner, **last once* is excluded "for the same reason as" **last one time*, while *this last once* is fine (p. 589). One of their *JL* referees judged *this last once* ungrammatical, and they allow that speakers may vary (p. 586 n. 26). The searches of COCA, NOW, and iWeb found no relevant example of *this last once* or *the last once*, but they found the pattern with *twice*, their (33b) (p. 595), as in [*The last twice*] *I checked my 71 GT I got 29 to the gallon* (mgexp.com).[23] So the adjective after a determiner is attested, though not with *once*. The gap before a bare *once* is the one Section 4 weighed for *few*.[24] Fusion derives it from adjacency, and ordinary Head excludes it by its condition on pre-head adjectives, a further statement of a kind the grammar already contains. Their further example, *(*this*) *once last* with a silent head after *last* (p. 589), separates fusion from a silent head, not from ordinary Head.

Larger phrases and the other uses go the same way. A DP such as *more than once*, or a PP such as *up to twice*, is for Payne et al. a fused determiner-head on its own and a fused modifier-head after a determiner (pp. 589–591 and n. 31), and ordinary Head puts each in the head function alone. Singulative and past *once* take no determiner and no attributive adjective (p. 592), and both gaps fall under what's already been weighed: the determiner under the default of Section 4, the adjective under the trade counted for *few*.

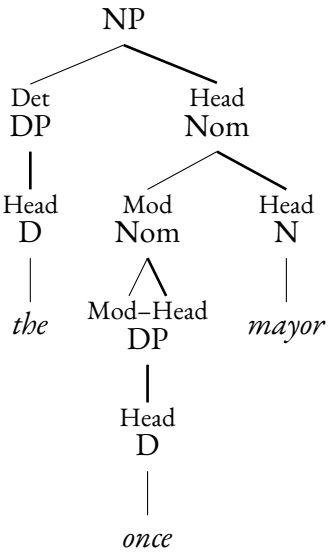
Term-of-office *once* functions as attributive modifier (*the once mayor*), as does *twice* in *the twice president*, which many speakers find unnatural (pp. 593, 595). Both analyses have to state that the use is largely confined to names of offices (**my once job as a glass-blower*, pp. 585, 593). For Payne et al.,

[23] Searched by hand on 18 October 2026. With `this last.[md*] once`, *last* tagged as an ordinal, COCA and NOW have no hits, and the plain string `this last once` gives COCA nothing and NOW and iWeb only the verb *last* (*How long does this last once the oils are mixed?*) and a slip for *this last one*; `this last twice` has no hits in any of the three. With the plain string `the last once`, no line in the three corpora clearly has *once* heading a nominal: most are slips for *one* or *ounce*, or have *once* as an adverb or the sequential preposition. NOW has 290 tokens of *the last twice*, and all 180 of its displayed lines have *twice* heading the NP, 176 of them from British or Irish sources, most of them racing reports (*He's gone well* [*the last twice*], *Racing Post*, 2026). iWeb has 28 such lines of 39, and COCA none.

[24] In 97 COCA lines of *a*, a word that can be tagged as an adjective, and *once* or *twice*, none has an adjective before *once* or *twice* heading a nominal after *a*, as in *a lucky few*. The adjective comes before *once* only in the noun *once-over* (*a quick once-over*, 17 lines) and in *once-in-a-lifetime* (3). In the rest, *once* or *twice* is outside the NP (*I saw* [*a psychic*] *once*). Nothing here calls for the statement that *a lucky few* needs on both analyses.

once here "will act as a fused modifier-head forming a nominal rather than forming a full NP" (p. 593), so the attribute is a nominal whose head is also its modifier. On ordinary Head the determinative *once* simply functions as modifier in the nominal *once mayor*, as *two* does in *the two books*. That's one function where fusion has two, and one nominal fewer (Figure 4), though the lexical statement is no shorter.

(a) *the once mayor*, fusion



(b) *the once mayor*, ordinary Head

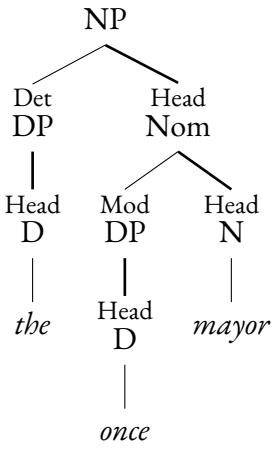


Figure 4: Term-of-office *once* under fusion (a) and ordinary Head (b). Payne et al. don't draw (a); it follows their description of *once* as "a fused modifier-head forming a nominal" that functions as attributive modifier (pp. 593, 595). In (b) the DP is a modifier in the nominal and nothing else, as *two* is in *the two books*.

The rest of their case (multiplier *twice*, *once a week*, and the non-standard uses, pp. 595–597) turns on category and on the word heading a nominal, which the analyses share.

Apart from the adjective restriction weighed in Section 4, no property of form in this paradigm varies with the second function rather than with the word,[25] so on the criterion of Section 2 the paradigm fusion was developed on adds no evidence of its own. Where their structures differ, in the term-of-office use, ordinary Head has the fewer functions.

6 What each analysis states

Sections 3 and 4 compared the two analyses construction by construction. Table 1 puts the results together. Both columns use *CGEL*'s categories and the same lexical facts, so what the table compares is how each analysis has to state them.

[25] The genitive, which divides the fused determiner-heads word by word (Section 3), is absent from all the uses: the searches of COCA, NOW, and iWeb found no genitive of *once*, *twice*, or *thrice*. Ordinary Head adds the three words to its list of gaps. Fusion predicts the gap, unless it lets a compound's nominal base carry the genitive, as in *everyone's* (Section 3), and then *·ce* needs an exception.

Table 1: What fusion and ordinary Head state for the heads *CGEL* fuses: determinatives, adjectives, nouns such as *nylon*, and *once*, *twice*, and *thrice*. Above the line, the two analyses state the same content, each in its own terms; below it, they differ.

	Fusion (*CGEL*)	Ordinary Head
Determinatives that stand alone (*some*, normally not *every*)	A list of the words that allow Det–Head	The same list, as permissions to head a nominal with no determiner
The forms *none* and *mine*	Dependent form as determiner, independent form as head (p. 410)	The same
Determinatives that head a nominal after a determiner (*the few*)	A default from the modifier use, with exceptions both ways: head but not modifier (*some*, *both*), modifier but not head (*every*, *various*)	The same default and exceptions, as permissions
A post-head modifier in that use, cardinals apart (*the many who did*)	Normally needed (p. 416)	The same condition
A restrictor after a compound (*nothing sensible*)	Derived from fusion (p. 423), but kept after conversion, so also stated for the word (Section 3)	Permitted after the compound as head
Determiners these heads take	Word by word: a plural noun's range for *few* (*those chosen few*); *the* or a genitive for *rich* (p. 417), none for *blue*	The same
A few and its expansions (*a lucky few*)	A modifier after *a* in the DP headed by *few* (Section 4); on *CGEL*'s other route, a list of sequences with *a* that take a plural head (p. 353)	The same
Adjectives that head a nominal	*CGEL*'s types, with exclusions such as **the main* (pp. 415–417)	The same list, as permissions
Genitive on a determinative standing alone	The gap predicted for all, with a list of exceptions (*either's*, *neither's*, *each's*; compounds such as *everyone's*, unless their nominal base carries it)	The genitive expected, with a list of gaps (*all*, *many*, *few*, *some*; *once*, *twice*, *thrice*)
Change of category on the head path	Where a DP or AdjP heads a nominal, or a PP (*up to twice*, Payne et al., p. 589 n. 31)	The same
Once, *twice*, and *thrice*	Numerical uses Det–Head alone and Mod–Head after a determiner; singulative and past uses Det–Head only (Payne et al., pp. 588, 592); sequential use a preposition (p. 594)	The same uses, as permissions to head a nominal with or without a determiner (numerical) or only without one (singulative, past)
A second function for the head of the nominal	Determiner for a determinative with no determiner before it; modifier for one after a determiner, and for adjectives and nouns such as *nylon*; term-of-office *once* a nominal of its own as attribute (Payne et al., p. 593)	None outside fused relatives, so *few* heads its nominal in the same way in *few would dare*, *few of them*, *the few*, and *the lucky few*; term-of-office *once* a modifier, as *two* is in *the two books*
A pre-head adjective with no determiner (**Lucky few escaped*)	Excluded by adjacency, as for the compounds (p. 423); *Poor everybody!* needs further treatment (Section 4)	Excluded by a condition: only after a determiner. *CGEL* states a restriction of this kind for pronouns (p. 430), and *everybody* and *everyone* join their exception

Above the line, the content is shared. The lists, defaults, and conditions follow the word, as Sections 3 and 4 found, and each analysis phrases them in its own terms: fusion as licences for a fused function, ordinary Head as permissions to head a nominal.

Below the line is the trade, and fusion has a good case. The grammar keeps constituents with two functions for fused relatives anyway (Section 7), so giving one to a determinative that stands alone adds no new kind of structure, and it derives a restriction ordinary Head has to state: no pre-head adjective before a bare determinative. Ordinary Head has no second function outside fused relatives and states the condition instead, a statement of the kind *CGEL* already makes for pronouns (p. 430; Section 4). What it gains is generality: *few* heading the same kind of NP gets one structure, where fusion gives it one pair of functions with no determiner and another after one. That's the kind of gain *CGEL* claims for fusion against traditional grammar (p. 419; Section 4). The compounds' restrictor, which Payne et al. also credit to fusion, goes with the word on both analyses (Section 3).

The two departures Payne et al. (2007, pp. 570–571) distinguish fall differently too. Fusion puts both on one constituent wherever a DP, AdjP, or PP is a fused head, since that phrase has two functions and is also where the category changes. Ordinary Head never puts both on one constituent. Its constituents with two functions are in fused relatives, where the fused phrase and its parent must project the same lexical category (p. 574), so no category changes there. In a bare fused relative such as *I'll take* [*whichever he gave me*], the two meet in one NP at different nodes: the DP heads the nominal, and the NP is head and prenucleus at once (Section 7, Figure 6).

On the criterion of Section 2, shape, dependents, the determiners taken, and the genitive show neither function (Sections 3 and 4). For the determiner function the only comparison available is between a determinative standing alone and the same word after a determiner, since *CGEL* gives determinatives no use as a pure head, and it changes two things at once: the word loses its determiner function, and a determiner precedes it. A fact that separates the two uses could follow from either change, so it counts for the determiner function, but for less than a contrast in the function alone would.

The pre-head adjective does show something, and it counts for fusion. *Few* takes none standing alone in COCA's edited prose and takes one after *the*, and fusion derives the difference from adjacency, where ordinary Head states a condition. *A lucky few* isn't an exception on either analysis of *a*, and *Poor everybody!* needs a further statement on both (Section 4). Against that fact are the generality ordinary Head gains for *few* and the constituent with two parents that fusion gives every NP headed by a bare determinative. I take the balance to favour ordinary Head, as a reasonable preference against a real advantage for fusion, not as a forced conclusion. The balance would shift if the same adjacency predicted further restrictions on bare determinatives, ones that ordinary Head could only list.

The saving is in where fusion applies, not in whether the grammar has it. Ordinary Head keeps constituents with two functions for fused relatives, so it removes them from noun phrases without a relative clause, not from the grammar. What it gains there is one head relation for each word across its uses, with constituents with two parents confined to the construction where the comparison favours keeping them. The verdicts differ in strength. Mod–Head is the clearest case against fusion, since nothing in the form shows the modifier function. Det–Head is the preference just described. In fused relatives (Section 7) the evidence favours fusion, and usage adds to what *CGEL*'s judgments show.

7 Fused relatives: where the second function shows

Payne et al. (2007, p. 571) list the dependents that fusion involves in English as "determiner, modifier and, in fused relative clauses, subject or prenucleus". Sections 3 and 4 found one fact of form that shows a second function in Det–Head expressions, the missing adjective, and none in Mod–Head ones. Fused relatives are the remaining test. *CGEL* brings fusion to them in so many words: "we invoke the same concept of functional fusion in our analysis of fused relatives" (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 1073).[26]

(4) a. *I spent* [*whatever he gave me*]. (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 1068)
b. [*Whoever told you that*] *can't have read the report carefully.* (p. 1076)
c. *I'll go* [*wherever you go*]. (p. 1068)

In (4a), *whatever* is head of the object NP and prenucleus of the relative clause, with a gap after *gave me* (Huddleston and Pullum, 2002, p. 1073; Figure 5a). In (4b), *whoever* is head of the subject NP and also the subject of *told you that*, which Payne et al. (2007, 579 n. 16) call "fused head-subject". The criterion asks whether the function inside the relative clause shows in form.

Ordinary Head is available here too. *Whomever I see* could be an NP headed by *whomever*, with a bare relative as modifier in its nominal, just as *person* heads *the person I see*. Put in *CGEL*'s terms, it's the analysis Bresnan and Grimshaw (1978) proposed: the relativized phrase heads the whole NP, and "there is no fronted element in the relative clause" (Payne et al., 2007, p. 578). It needs nothing beyond ordinary Head and a kind of relative clause the grammar already has, and I'll call it the head analysis (Figure 5b).

[26] Transparent free relatives, as in *He made* [*what may appear to be a radically new proposal*] (Grosu, 2003, p. 248), raise different questions and are set aside here (Grosu, 2003, 2016).

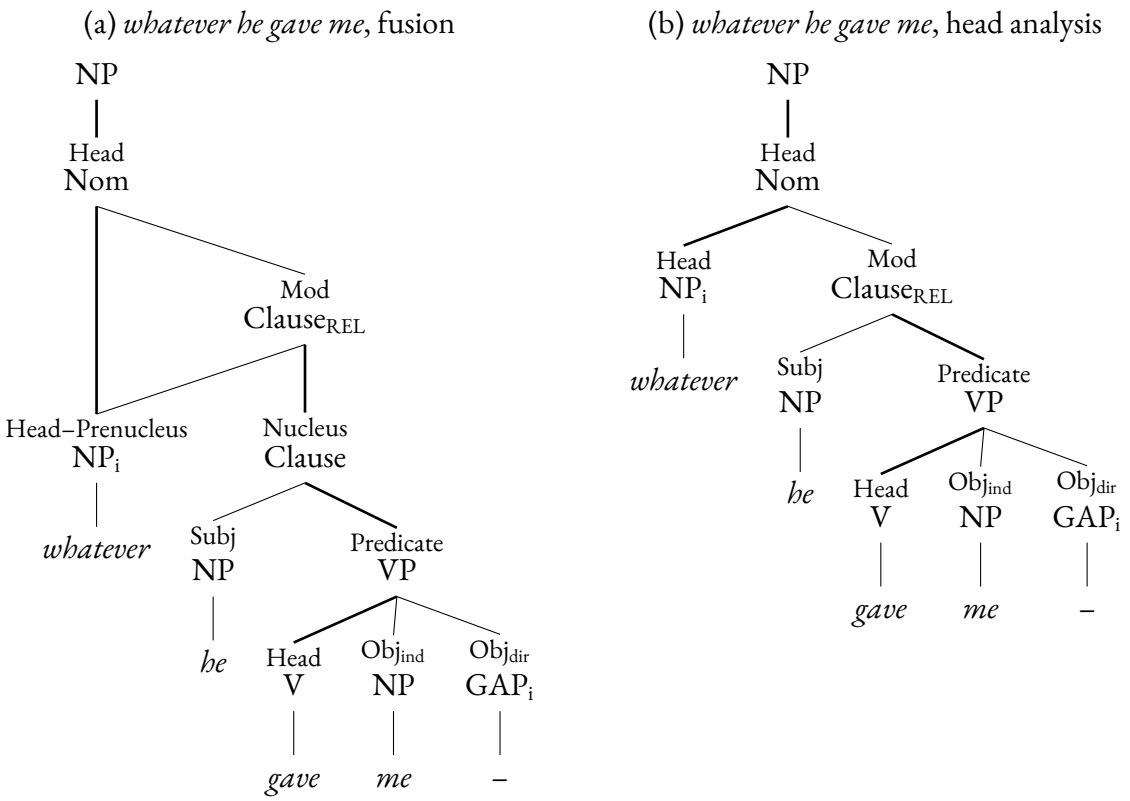


Figure 5: A fused relative under fusion (a), following *CGEL*'s tree for *what she wrote* (p. 1073), and under the head analysis (b). In (a) the NP *whatever* has two parents, the nominal it heads and the relative clause in which it's the prenucleus, linked to the gap. In (b) the NP heads the nominal, outside the bare relative clause that is its modifier. Thick lines join heads to their parents, the nucleus counting as head of the relative clause. Other NPs are shown without their structure, as in *CGEL*'s tree.

Much comes out the same. The evidence that fused relatives are NPs holds on either: agreement, subject–auxiliary inversion, no extraposition, no fronted preposition, and the functions of NPs (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 1068–1070). So does what the literature calls matching, in which the relativized phrase's category suits "categorial selection both in the matrix clause and in the relative clause" (van Riemsdijk, 2006, p. 349). Bresnan and Grimshaw (1978, pp. 336–338) derive the match with the matrix from headedness, since a phrase has the category of its head, and on either analysis the match with the gap comes from the relative clause. So category matching doesn't separate the two analyses. Three other properties do.

First, in standard English bare relatives can't relativize their subject. *CGEL* contrasts [*The car I took*] *was Ed's* with *[*The car hit us*] *was Ed's*, and the restriction holds whatever the head: ![*Anyone wants this*] *can have it* is non-standard (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 1055).[27] *Anyone* is a compound determinative, and it heads its NP whether it's an ordinary Head (Section 3) or a fused determiner-head. So that example has the head analysis's structure, a head with a bare relative, and it fails. Holding the frame constant gives the same contrast with a fused relative:

[27] The mark ! is *CGEL*'s, for a form it treats as non-standard.

(5) a. *I will do business with* [*whichever of them comes up with the cash*]. (Payne et al., 2007, 579 n. 16)
b. !*I will do business with* [*any of them comes up with the cash*].
c. *I will do business with* [*whichever of them you recommend*].
d. *I will do business with* [*any of them you recommend*].

With an object gap, *any of them* takes a bare relative freely (5d), so only the relativized subject separates (5a) from (5b). On the fused analysis, *whichever of them* is itself the subject of *comes up with the cash*.[28] The clause has no subject gap, and the restriction doesn't apply. The head analysis has to give relative words a licence that the restriction withholds from every other head.

Second, ordinary heads take infinitival relatives without a relative word, as in *the ideal person* (*for you*) *to confide in* (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 1067), but a fused relative can't be infinitival: **I can't afford* [*what to buy*] (p. 1073). Kim (2017, pp. 364, 378) also gives **He is still wearing* [*what to wear to bed*] and **Tom will do* [*whatever to satisfy her*].

The head analysis predicts *what to buy* to be as good as *a thing to buy*. On the fused analysis, *what* would be the relative phrase of an infinitival relative clause, and there "the relative phrase must consist of preposition + NP" (p. 1067), as in *the ideal person* [*in whom*] *to confide*. The fused element of an NP fused relative is an NP, so it never qualifies.[29]

Third, case. *CGEL* names case as the form in which a second function would show (pp. 420, 1073–1074), and for fused relatives with *who* and *whoever* it states the requirement: the pronoun "has to satisfy the case requirements of both the relative clause and the matrix clause" (p. 1073).

(6) a. [*Whoever is responsible for the damage*] *must pay for it.* (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 1073–1074)
b. *He will criticise* [*whomever she brings home*].
c. ?[*Whomever he marries*] *will have to be very tolerant.*
d. ?*She lunches with* [*whomever is going her way after morning classes*].

In (6c), the relative clause calls for accusative and the matrix for nominative. In (6d) it's the reverse. *CGEL* judges both "at best very questionable" (p. 1074).

On the head analysis as stated so far, *whomever* stands outside the relative clause, so its form should answer to the matrix alone. That was the analysis's attraction for matching: the head "would automatically bear the case of the whole NP" (Payne et al., 2007, p. 578). Bresnan and Grimshaw (1978) add an agreement condition between the head and the gap, and languages differ on whether

[28] On *CGEL*'s analysis, *whichever* is fused twice here. Inside its own NP it's a fused determiner-head (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 398), and that NP is fused head and subject in the relative construction, which Payne et al. count as "multiple instances of fused functions" (p. 579 n. 16). Bare *whichever* in *I'll take* [*whichever he gave me*] is fused twice in the same way, with head and prenucleus. Ordinary Head removes the inner fusion, which shows nothing in form (Section 3), and keeps the outer one, which does (Figure 6).

[29] *CGEL* finds "no evident explanation" for that restriction (p. 1067), and the argument takes it as stated. *CGEL* also says infinitival relatives with a relative phrase occur only as integrated relatives (p. 1067), which would exclude fused ones directly. The restriction on the relative phrase covers NP fused relatives without that statement. It doesn't cover a PP fused relative whose relative phrase is a preposition with an NP, as in *I'll work* [*in whichever city they want me to work*] (Payne et al., 2007, p. 575). That **I'll work* [*in whichever city to work*] is out too rests on the statement about integrated relatives.

case is among the features that must agree: the head takes the subordinate verb's case in Finnish but not in Old English (pp. 353, 373–374). With case included, the head analysis can make *whomever* answer to the clause too, but only by a further statement, where fusion gets the same result from the prenucleus. Without it, the head analysis predicts (6c) to be degraded but not (6d). There *whomever* is the object of *with*, where accusative is the formal choice (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 465–466). The question mark on (6d) shows the subject function inside the relative clause.

CGEL's two dialects for *whom* point the same way. When *who* is the subject of a clause embedded in a relative, as in %*those* [*whom*] *he thought were guilty*, Dialect A takes its case from that function, and Dialect B from its "prenuclear position preceding the subject of the relative clause" (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 467). Both rules look inside the relative clause, and the head analysis puts *whomever* outside it, so it needs a condition linking the head's form to the relative clause here too. Agreement with the gap gives Dialect A's rule but not Dialect B's, which goes by position.

Usage shows the same thing directly, as a preference. After a preposition the matrix function is the same in nearly every token, so the head analysis without the agreement condition predicts the same choice of form whatever follows. In COCA, *whoever* and *whomever* occur after a preposition 802 times before a pronoun subject, as in *with whomever they* …, and *whomever* has 395 of those (49%). They occur there 2,458 times before a verb, where the gap is the subject, as in *to whomever is* …, and *whomever* has 352 of those (14%).[30]

So the function inside the relative clause shows in the form. The matrix function shows too, and not only after prepositions (Table 2). As the subject of the main clause, *whomever* is rare even with a non-subject gap ([*Whomever I chose for this experiment*] *should be close to the mean*, *Southern Review*, 2015).[31]

[30] COCA, searched by hand on 17 October 2026 with `[i*] who*ever [p*]` and `[i*] who*ever [v*]`. Tokens before *it* are left out, because *it* can be the subject of a clause whose gap is a predicative complement, as in *whoever it is*; of the 180 such tokens, *whomever* has 35. The verb list shows only its 1,000 most frequent types, so its counts are lower bounds; at most 43 of its *whoever* tokens follow a preposition that can introduce a clause (*like*, *after*, *until*), too few to move the share by half a point. In ordinary relatives with a subject gap, *whom* is rare by comparison, with 390 tokens of `[nn*] whom [v*]` against 449,450 of `[nn*] who [v*]`, so most subject-gap tokens of *whomever* owe their form to something outside the relative clause. A check of about 200 lines of each form (18 October) found a non-subject gap in all but one *whomever* line before a pronoun other than *it*, and in 131 of the 148 such *whoever* lines. The other *whoever* lines have a predicative gap (*for whoever she is*), the subject of an embedded clause (*whoever you think is guilty*), or a fused relative that is the subject of a clause after *until* or *before* (*until whoever you're waiting for gets here*). Without them the share is about 52%.

[31] COCA, 18 October 2026. The main clause's subject: `. whomever [p*]`, `. whoever [p*]`, `. whomever [v*]`, and `. whoever [v*]`, with all the *whomever* hits (23 and 42) and 500-line samples of the *whoever* hits (644 and 2,606); exhaustive conditionals (*Whoever you are, …*), interrogative for *CGEL* (p. 1072 n. 15), are left out. A verb's object: `[vv*] whomever [p*]`, `[vv*] whoever [p*]`, `[vv*] whomever [v*]`, and `[vv*] whoever [v*]`, with 199, 199, 71, and 200 lines read of 227, 555, 71, and 1,372 hits; predicative gaps (*find whoever it is*) are left out, and content-clause subjects counted apart. The 8-of-51 cell has a 95% interval of roughly 8–28%.

Table 2: The share of *whomever* among tokens of *whoever* and *whomever* in COCA, by the function of the fused relative and the gap in its relative clause. Figures marked "about" are estimated from labelled samples.

Fused relative	Subject gap	Non-subject gap
Object of a preposition	14% (352 of 2,458)	about 52% (393 of 753)
Object of a verb	6% (60 of about 970)	about 37% (206 of 562)
Subject of the main clause	under 2% (32 of about 2,100)	about 16% (8 of about 51)

In both columns the share falls from preposition to verb to subject, and in each row it's several times higher with a non-subject gap. Where the fused relative is the subject of a verb's content clause (*I think* [*whoever did this to her*] *wants to slow down her maturity*, *Wildling*, 2018), *whomever* has 9 of about 400 tokens with a subject gap, about 2%, as for the main clause's subject. The order holds in speech and scripts and in writing taken separately, though *whomever* is far rarer in the first.[32] So the form answers to both functions. *Whoever* is the default: *whomever* comes near half only where both functions call for accusative, and it's a minority in the clashes, one of which is (6c). Of the clashes, *whomever* has 6% where a verb's object has a subject gap and about 16% where the main clause's subject has a non-subject gap, so against a verb the function inside the relative clause counts for more; against a preposition the two clashes come out alike (14% and about 16%). Fusion predicts that a clash has no fully acceptable form, which is what *CGEL*'s question marks record; *CGEL* adds that *whoever* "would be preferable in both, but many would regard it as less than fully acceptable in formal style" (p. 1074). Usage shows both functions at work, though how strongly each counts, and how the two interact, I leave open. So case favours fusion here rather than forcing it.[33]

CGEL drew this analogy itself. Its explanation of the missing genitive in **many's expenses* is that the form's "case should match both functions", and it points to "the discussion of case in fused relatives" (p. 420). Among fused determiner-heads, the genitive divides the words: *many's* is all but absent, but *either's*, *each's*, and *everyone's* occur. That division follows the word, not the functions, which all these words share on *CGEL*'s analysis (Section 3), and *the poor's* puts the genitive on a fused modifier-head (Section 4). In fused relatives the word stays the same and the form follows the function inside the relative clause, as a preference. On the diagnostic *CGEL* itself chose, the two constructions come apart.

CGEL also has PP fused relatives (*I'll go* [*wherever you go*], p. 1068), and Payne et al. (2007, p. 575) add AdjPs and AdvPs (*I'll be* [*however responsive they want me to be*]). Case can't arise in them, but the first property can: in [*Whenever suits you*] *is fine*, the head analysis would have a bare relative with a subject gap. Both analyses can treat the four types as one construction, so the types don't separate

[32] Taking spoken, TV, and film lines as one group and the rest as the other, *whomever* has about 27% and 65% of the preposition-object cell with a non-subject gap, 11% and 58% of the verb-object one, 1 line of 21 and 29% of the main clause's subject with a non-subject gap, 2% and 9% of the verb-object cell with a subject gap, and under 1% and 3% of the main clause's subject with a subject gap. The preposition-object cell with a subject gap comes from frequency lists and can't be split. Fiction has dialogue and web texts are informal, so the split is rough.

[33] van Riemsdijk (2006, p. 357) finds that case matching concerns "the actual morpho-phonological shape of the case form": in German, where nominative and accusative *was* have the same form, a mismatch of the abstract cases passes. Which function's case wins a clash varies across languages (Payne et al., 2007, p. 578).

them, but on the head analysis it's again a construction whose head has licences no other head has, since "standard relative clauses are modifiers only within Nom" (p. 575).

So the second function shows in form in three ways, two of them categorical and one graded. The head analysis can state each, but only by giving fused-relative words licences no other head has: subject relativization without a relative word, no infinitival form, and case agreement with a gap in a clause the word isn't part of. Fusion gets all three from the rules for relative clauses that have a relative phrase.[34] So fusion is favoured here, though not forced. Fused relatives are the only construction in which this paper keeps it (Figure 6).

A dependency grammar has drawn the same line. In Word Grammar a word may depend on a word that depends on it, and Gisborne (2026, p. 2) argues that such mutual dependency should be dispreferred where an analysis without it is plausible and coherent. He gives it up for dependent interrogatives and keeps it for free relatives, where the *wh* word heads the construction and is also extracted, "the dependency variant of the 'fused relative' analysis" in *CGEL* (p. 16).[35]

[34] A constructional analysis reaches the same double relation by another route. Kim (2017, p. 376) makes the free relative construction a subtype of both the head-filler and the head-modifier constructions, so the relativized phrase is at once head and filler.

[35] The "fused word" analysis he considers, Tesnière's, is another notion: one morpho-phonological word realizing two syntactic words, as *we're* realizes *we* and *are*. He rejects it for relative pronouns for want of independent evidence such as commutation (p. 6).

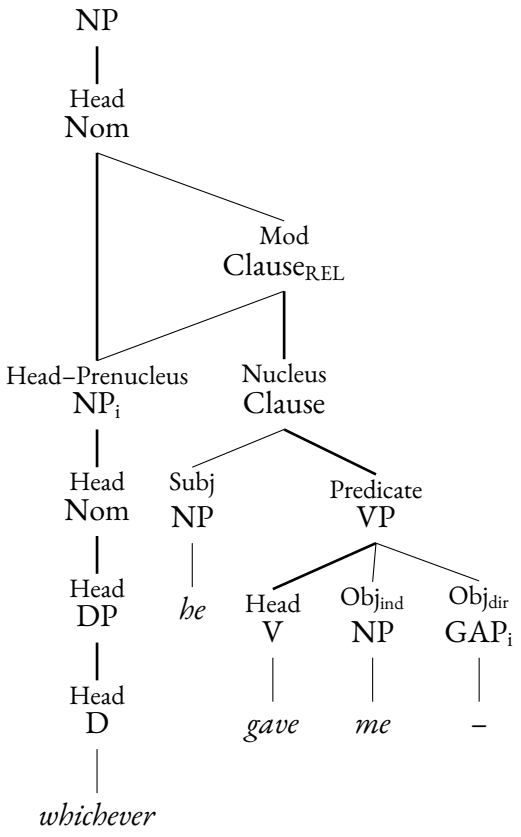


Figure 6: *Whichever he gave me* as this paper analyses it. Inside its NP, *whichever* is an ordinary head, where *CGEL* has a second fusion (p. 398). The NP is still head of the nominal and prenucleus of the relative clause at once, as in Figure 5a.

8 Conclusion

On the commitments held fixed in Section 2, this paper finds no property of form that shows the modifier function where *CGEL* fuses the head of a noun phrase with a modifier (*the lucky few*, *the rich*), the clearest of its results, and Payne et al.'s *once*, *twice*, and *thrice* add none (Sections 4 and 5). For the determiner function (*take some*) it finds one, the absence of an adjective before a bare determinative, which fusion derives and ordinary Head states (Section 3). Against it, ordinary Head gives *few* one head relation across its uses and avoids a constituent with two parents, and the balance favours ordinary Head without forcing it (Section 6).

Noun-phrase fused relatives supply the evidence the criterion asks for, in two properties categorically and in a third as a preference (Section 7). The relative word's function inside its clause shows in subject relativization and in the ban on infinitival fused relatives, and in usage the case of *whoever* answers both to that function and to the function of the whole phrase. So fusion survives, favoured though not forced, as a device the grammar licenses for one construction, not as the general answer to a noun phrase with no noun.

References

Aarts, B. (2024). On so-called fused constructions [Talk at the 26th International Symposium on Theoretical and Applied Linguistics, Thessaloniki, 19–21 April 2024]. https://www.new.enl.auth.gr/istal26/?p=451

Bresnan, J., & Grimshaw, J. (1978). The syntax of free relatives in English. *Linguistic Inquiry*, *9*(3), 331–391. https://www.jstor.org/stable/4178069

Davies, M. (2008–present). The Corpus of Contemporary American English (COCA).

Davies, M. (2016–present). Corpus of News on the Web (NOW).

Davies, M. (2018). The iWeb corpus.

Gisborne, N. (2026). Mutual dependency, English *wh*-clauses and Word Grammar [First View]. *Journal of Linguistics*, 1–30. https://doi.org/10.1017/S002222672610125X

Grosu, A. (2003). A unified theory of standard and transparent free relatives. *Natural Language and Linguistic Theory*, *21*(2), 247–331. https://doi.org/10.1023/A:1023387128941

Grosu, A. (2016). The semantics, syntax, and morphology of transparent free relatives revisited: A comparison of two approaches. *Natural Language and Linguistic Theory*, *34*(4), 1245–1280. https://doi.org/10.1007/s11049-016-9333-0

Halm, T. (2021, June). *Virtual performatives in English: The outlines of a syntactic analysis* [Manuscript, LingBuzz 006012. A version appeared as "Modified pronouns and split agreement: The syntax of virtual performatives", *NELS 52*, pp. 319–329]. https://lingbuzz.net/lingbuzz/006012

Huddleston, R., & Pullum, G. K. (2002). *The Cambridge grammar of the English language*. Cambridge University Press. https://doi.org/10.1017/9781316423530

Kayne, R. S. (2007). Several, few and many. *Lingua*, *117*(5), 832–858. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.lingua.2006.03.005

Kester, E.-P. (1996). Adjectival inflection and the licensing of empty categories in DP. *Journal of Linguistics*, *32*(1), 57–78. https://doi.org/10.1017/S0022226700000761

Kim, J.-B. (2017). Mixed properties and matching effects in English free relatives: A construction-based perspective. *Linguistic Research*, *34*(3), 361–385. https://doi.org/10.17250/khisli.34.3.201712.006

Lobeck, A. (1995). *Ellipsis: Functional heads, licensing, and identification*. Oxford University Press. https://doi.org/10.1093/oso/9780195091816.001.0001

Matthews, P. H. (2014). *The positions of adjectives in English*. Oxford University Press. https://doi.org/10.1093/acprof:oso/9780199681594.001.0001

Miller, P., & Pullum, G. K. (2022). La tête du groupe nominal: L'hypothèse du DP dans les théories génératives. *Revue CORELA*, (HS-37). https://journals.openedition.org/corela/15038

Panagiotidis, P. (2003). Empty nouns. *Natural Language & Linguistic Theory*, *21*(2), 381–432. https://doi.org/10.1023/A:1023384924981

Payne, J., Huddleston, R., & Pullum, G. K. (2007). Fusion of functions: The syntax of *once*, *twice* and *thrice*. *Journal of Linguistics*, *43*(3), 565–603. https://doi.org/10.1017/S002222670700477X

Postal, P. M. (1966). On so-called "pronouns" in English. In F. P. Dinneen (Ed.), *Report of the seventeenth annual round table meeting on linguistics and language studies* (pp. 177–206). Georgetown University Press.

Pullum, G. K., & Rogers, J. (2008). *Expressive power of the syntactic theory implicit in The Cambridge Grammar of the English Language* [Unpublished manuscript; presented at the annual meeting of the Linguistics Association of Great Britain, Essex]. Retrieved May 24, 2026, from https://lel.ed.ac.uk/~gpullum/EssexLAGB.pdf

Quirk, R., Greenbaum, S., Leech, G., & Svartvik, J. (1985). *A comprehensive grammar of the English language*. Longman.

Reynolds, B. (2026). The lexicon–syntax boundary in English numerals: Cardinals, ordinals, and fractionals [Published online 4 February 2026]. *English Language and Linguistics*, 1–19. https://doi.org/10.1017/S1360674325100518

Reynolds, B., Schneider, N., & Arora, A. (2025). *CGELBank annotation manual v1.2* [arXiv preprint]. https://doi.org/10.48550/arXiv.2305.17347

Saab, A. (2019). Nominal ellipsis. In J. van Craenenbroeck & T. Temmerman (Eds.), *The Oxford handbook of ellipsis* (pp. 526–561). Oxford University Press. https://doi.org/10.1093/oxfordhb/9780198712398.013.26

Salzmann, M. (2020). The NP vs. DP debate: Why previous arguments are inconclusive and what a good argument could look like. Evidence from agreement with hybrid nouns. *Glossa: a journal of general linguistics*, *5*(1), 83. https://doi.org/10.5334/gjgl.1123

van Riemsdijk, H. (2006). Free relatives. In M. Everaert & H. van Riemsdijk (Eds.), *The Blackwell companion to syntax* (pp. 338–382). Blackwell.

Wu, Z. (2021). *Exocentric noun phrases in English* [Doctoral dissertation, University College London]. https://discovery.ucl.ac.uk/id/eprint/10118908/